presented an outline of the missile programme before the professors and the aspiring students, about 350 of them, and requested them to participate. I informed the reviewers that we were expecting around 300 young engineers to join our laboratories.

Roddam Narasimha, then Director of the National Aeronautical Laboratory, used the occasion of this review to put up a strong case for technology initiative. He cited the experiences of the green revolution, which had demonstrated beyond doubt that if the goals were clear, there was enough talent available in the country to tackle major technological chal enges.

When India carried out its first nuclear explosion for peaceful purposes, we declared ourselves the sixth country in the world to explode a nuclear device. When we launched SLV-3 we were the fifth country to achieve satel ite launch capability. When were we going to be the first or second country in the world to achieve a technological feat?

I listened careful y to the review members as they aired their opinions and doubts, and I learned from their col ective wisdom. It was indeed a great education for me. Ironical y,